say these have imposed stricter conditions on HEIs for recognition and receiving government funding.
Just a while ago, you asked me about filling up vacancies in universities. The new rules require universities to fill at least 75 per cent of their sanctioned positions to be eligible for central assistance. Additionally, universities must develop an institutional development plan (IDP). These guidelines serve as incentives for institutions to develop in the right direction. Higher education institutes have six months to create and submit their IDPs to the UGC. A group of experts will evaluate these plans and select the 10 best IDPs. Leaders from these top institutes will then be invited to share their IDPs with other institutional leaders so that others can learn from these.

Q. The UGC has published a list of central universities that have been granted Graded Autonomy. How will it change things for them?
Universities demonstrating a certain quality of education, infrastructure and research achievements are categorised into three levels, each with varying autonomy. Category 1 universities, for instance, can open off-campus centres without UGC inspection and offer online courses without lengthy approval processes. That's the level of trust shown for these institutes.

Q. How is the UGC improving transparency in university accreditation under the NAAC?
Accreditation assesses the overall health of an institution across various parameters. This process is both data-driven and includes physical visits by teams. There has been some criticism regarding data analysis and the objectivity of physical visits. Last year, the Radhakrishnan committee submitted several recommendations to strengthen the accreditation process. Consequently, we have introduced a scheme of binary accreditation and maturity-based accreditation.

Binary accreditation is a data-driven approach based on certain minimum criteria that apply to all institutions, regardless of their level of excellence. We aim to include around 90-95 per cent of institutions in the scope of binary accreditation. The next step is maturity level accreditation, which has five levels—from 1 to 5. Levels 1 to 4 are for institutions that have demonstrated excellence within India, while Level 5 is reserved for institutions that have shown global excellence. This process involves more detailed inspections of institutions and their data. Currently, the NAAC is conducting national-level workshops to raise awareness about this new process.

Q. Recently, several entrance tests conducted by the National Testing Agency, including the UGC-NET, have come under a cloud. Is it a systemic failure?
To ensure admissions are fair and unbiased in a large and diverse country like ours, they must be entirely based on objectivity, which is why entrance exams are necessary. While every system has its deficiencies, I do not believe the recent controversies surrounding NTA-conducted exams are due to systemic failures. Whenever a robust system is created, there will always be elements that try to exploit it. We don't shut down online financial transactions because of cyber attacks and frauds; instead, we build more resilient systems to withstand such attacks. Similarly, rather than weakening our system by criticising the NTA, we need to strengthen it by developing more robust processes. This is why the government has formed a committee to recommend reforms.

"WE DON'T SHUT DOWN ONLINE TRANSACTIONS BECAUSE OF CYBER FRAUD. LIKEWISE, WE MUST MAKE NTA STRONGER, NOT CRITICISE IT"

Q. What is the new Life Skills Curriculum introduced by the UGC?
As technology becomes more prevalent in our lives, students must possess basic knowledge in various areas beyond their chosen discipline to navigate the real world effectively. For instance, they need better skills in communication and financial management, and they also need to understand how to conduct themselves ethically in both professional and personal lives. These skills cannot be taught solely in classrooms; they must be acquired through real-life experiences. Therefore, we are encouraging universities to involve students in community services, sports, cultural activities and debating clubs.

Students are becoming overly focused on competition and success. However, they also need to develop the ability to lead balanced lives. They should value the importance of good health and physical activity, know how to maintain cordial relationships and handle crises positively. Our institutional spaces should provide opportunities for students to think multi-dimensionally, helping them become better human beings. This is the rationale behind the introduction of this curriculum.

Q. Finally, when will we see the Higher Education Commission of India?
I'm confident the government will make a decision at the appropriate time. Meanwhile, the UGC and other regulators are in constant dialogue to bring synergy to our guidelines and regulations. ■